235 crore, the French were again negotiating for a deal worth Rs 900 crore. The enormity of the historical blunder of turning down the French offer of 1974 dawned on me while chatting with a French official in the 1990s. When he spoke of the Rs 900 crore they were expecting, I casually asked him if he remembered an offer they had made fifteen years earlier to sell a cryogenic engine for Rs 1 crore.

'Yes, I know,' said the French official. 'And I also know that it would have been the most foolish deal we would have made.'

Another negotiator chipped in, 'Back then, we didn't know the value of a cryo engine. You realise the worth of anything only when there are takers. We had the engine and wanted to sell, but there were no takers.'

It became abundantly clear to everyone that India had let go of a golden opportunity, but Seshan never harped on the message he took to Dhawan, the snub he got and the revenge he relished. True to the spirit of the Indian civil services, Seshan never displayed insubordination, but never shied away from putting forth his opinion. His bosses may have had their way, but Seshan had his say. And, when he was vested with the powers, he showed how to wield it—and show results.

Seshan, who wore many hats, is today known to many Indians as the former Chief Election Commissioner of India. Holding this post from 1990 to 1996, Seshan showed what the real powers of the CEC were. How many of his successors learned how to put their foot down is history that the political class is yet to digest. Feeling helpless when Seshan tightened his grip on overspending candidates during general elections, one politician called him an Alsatian. Seshan enjoyed the sobriquet, and even popularised it. At public meetings, when he is introduced to the audience, he would say: 'For some I am T N Seshan, for a few others, I am AL-Seshan.'

Seshan remains a friend and well-wisher of mine. Years later, in 1997 when the Supreme Court was sitting in judgment of the ISRO spy case, Seshan was among the signatories of an open letter that asked to end the harassment meted out to me.

The open letter said: 'We are choosing this route to express our concern because of our inability to intervene meaningfully in the complicated chess